formidable natural forces such as storms and earthquakes, but they were far less dependent on the wishes of other animals. A farm boy learned early on to ride a horse, harness a bull, whip a stubborn donkey and lead the sheep to pasture. It was easy and tempting to believe that such everyday activities reflected either the natural order of things or the will of heaven.

It is no coincidence that the Nayaka of southern India treat elephants, snakes and forest trees as beings equal to humans, but have a very different view of domesticated plants and animals. In the Nayaka language a living being possessing a unique personality is called *mansan*. When probed by the anthropologist Danny Naveh, they explained that all elephants are *mansan*. 'We live in the forest, they live in the forest. We are all *mansan*…So are bears, deer and tigers. All forest animals.' What about cows? 'Cows are different. You have to lead them everywhere.' And chickens? 'They are nothing. They are not *mansan*.' And forest trees? 'Yes – they live for such a long time.' And tea bushes? 'Oh, these I cultivate so that I can sell the tea leaves and buy what I need from the store. No, they aren't *mansan*.'[31]

We should also bear in mind how humans themselves were treated in most agricultural societies. In biblical Israel or medieval China it was common to whip humans, enslave them, torture and execute them. Humans were considered as mere property. Rulers did not dream of asking peasants for their opinions and cared little about their needs. Parents frequently sold their children into slavery, or married them off to the highest bidder. Under such conditions, ignoring the feelings of cows and chickens was hardly surprising.

Five Hundred Years of Solitude

The rise of modern science and industry brought about the next revolution in human–animal relations. During the Agricultural Revolution humankind silenced animals and plants, and turned the animist grand opera into a dialogue between man and gods. During the Scientific Revolution humankind silenced the gods too. The world was now a one-man show. Humankind stood alone on